

Sources and History of *Othello*

"It happened that a virtuous lady of wondrous beauty called Desdemona, impelled not by female appetite but by the Moor's good qualities, fell in love with him, and he, vanquished by the Lady's beauty and noble mind, likewise was enamoured of her."

This was the seed from which *Othello*, the "greatest of domestic dramas," sprang. The passage comes from Giraldo Cinthio's short story "Il Moro Di Venezia" (or "Un Capitano Moro"), from an Italian collection of stories, *Gli Hecatommithi* (1565). Shakespeare and many other English dramatists were reading this popular work at the beginning of the seventeenth century. [Selections from this story can be found on p13 of this study guide.] Shakespeare found his plot and the suggestions for his characters in Cinthio's narrative though he took many liberties in his adaptation. Although Desdemona is the only named character in Cinthio's work, the parallels between Cinthio's other characters and Shakespeare's are quite clear. "The Moor" from the short story became Othello, "The Ensign" became Iago, "The Squadron Leader" became Cassio, and "The Ensign's Wife" became Shakespeare's Emilia. In addition, it is believed that Shakespeare also borrowed details from the French novelist Belleforest, and background material from various historical references of the day. Scholars estimate that Shakespeare penned this great tragedy sometime between 1602 and 1604.

Some of Shakespeare's interest in writing this play is also believed to have come from the presence of a Moorish embassy in London. In August of 1600, the ambassador of the King of Barbary and his retinue arrived in England for a 'half year's abode in London'. Their Muslim customs and manners were considered strange in the eyes of the locals, and the ambassadors caused quite a stir in London. The first audiences to see *Othello* performed no doubt would have the image of the Barbarians, as they were called, fresh in their minds.

The play was performed at court of King James I in 1604. The titular role was played by Richard Burbage, who was also famed for originating the roles of Hamlet, Richard III and King Lear. Subsequent public performances at the Globe Theatre were numerous and attest to the play's popularity at the time. *Othello* was first printed in the *First Quarto* in 1622. Since that time, Shakespeare's tragedy of the Venetian Moor has had an active performance history. Iago and Othello are both considered coveted roles by classical actors. During much of the play's early history, and even recently, Othello was most often played by a white actor in dark make-up. Sir Laurence

Olivier and Orson Wells are two of the most famous caucasian actors to perform the role in "black-face." In 1833, Ira Aldridge was the first black man to play the role on the London stage. Since then many black actors have played the role, including actor-singer Paul Robeson, whose 1943 production ran for nearly 300 performances, and still holds the record for the most performances of any Shakespeare play ever produced on Broadway.

The issues of racial and cultural sensitivity seems inextricably tied to this play, and, particularly for American audiences, can be very provocative. Trevor Nunn's 1999 production, featuring Ian McKellan as Iago, for example was set against the backdrop of the post-Civil War south. More recently however, directors and actors have attempted to focus on *Othello* as a piece not about bigotry against blacks or Muslims, but rather as a comment on otherness; Othello is an outsider in Venice, regardless of race. This is most apparent in cross-racial cast productions such as Patrick Stewart's 2000 performance as a lone white soldier in a world of black and Middle Eastern politicians, generals and diplomats.

It is, however, the play's universal themes of jealousy, trust, innocence and naiveté, as well as its a broad scope of human emotion that have made *Othello* one of Shakespeare's most challenging and popular plays. It is performed frequently, and been the source of numerous films (including the 2001 "*O*" set in a wealthy New York high school), operas and ballets. Verdi's *Otello* is a staple in the repertory of many opera companies. As each production interprets the play through its own cultural and historical lens, *Othello* continues to captivate audiences and resonate on many personal as well as social levels.



Robert Cuccioli as Iago. Photo: Gerry Goodstein ©2011.

The Jealous Outsider(s)

On the surface, *Othello* is often seen as merely a play about a jealous outsider who is gulled by a manipulative villain. One loses a great deal that this masterpiece has to offer by cramming it into these simple (and somewhat erroneous) terms. Certainly, one cannot examine *Othello* without considering the issues of race and the cultural outsider. But this is a deeply human and personal tragedy. Unlike Shakespeare's other great dramas in which domestic strife leads to national turmoil, *Othello's* upheavals are wholly domestic, with themes of jealousy, trust, and honesty echoing throughout the play.

THE OUTSIDER:

Othello is an outsider in the world of Shakespeare's play. He is a Moor in a world of Venetians. He is black (or tawny in some

productions) in a world of white men and women. He is a soldier in a world of nobles. His cultural ways, curious to the Venetians, also are considered frightening or the cause for suspicion. Othello, though, has a desire to belong. In his newly adopted world, he serves faithfully the government of Venice and falls in love with the fair Desdemona. As a military man, he claims to be unskilled in the art of oration as he pleads to the Duke. His unease in the ways of love and courtship

in this strange land require him to use Cassio as a go-between with Desdemona. The vulnerability born of being an outsider, is an important ingredient that allows Iago's manipulations to destroy him.

Othello is not, however, the only outsider in Shakespeare's tragedy. Desdemona is banished from her father's home after he discovers her marriage to Othello. Cassio is an outsider in the Venetian army. Though promoted to lieutenant, he is a Florentine, and his weak brain for alcohol places him as an outsider in the soldiers' celebrations. Roderigo is an outsider in Cyprus, having followed the Venetian army at the prompting of Iago. Bianca is an outsider in a man's world without any

contact (until after the attack on Cassio) with either of the other two women in the play. Possibly the most compelling outsider in the play, however, is Iago. Unlike the other characters in the play, Othello's disgruntled ensign casts himself in the role of outsider. As an observer and manipulator, he keeps a calculated distance from others even as he seems to be closest to their hearts. His role as the outsider not only spurs his rage, but is also essential to the successful completion of his plots against Othello, Desdemona, and Cassio.

THE GREEN-EYED MONSTER:

Most often, academics refer to Othello as the "jealous Moor." Based on all that is said about him in the play, however, this label seems inappropriate. He is *not* a jealous man, but rather a noble, level-headed, honest, loving and respected man whose one bout of jealousy brings about his ultimate destruction. The theme of jealousy, though, touches many people in the play. Bianca is jealous of Cassio's newest love interest (who does not exist). Roderigo is jealous for the love Desdemona shows to Othello, as well as the love he *believes* she shows to Cassio (which does not exist). Emilia seems jealous of the loving and true relationship Desdemona shares with Othello early in the play.

The most jealous character in the play, however, is Iago himself. One may see him as simply the "villainous ensign," but it is his chronic and obsessive envy and jealousy that sparks his villainy. Some of the people Iago suggests (or outright states) that he is jealous of are:

- Othello for his position as general
- Cassio for being promoted by Othello to lieutenant
- Othello for the love Desdemona bears him

He seems obsessed with these jealousies and, in fact, they are the fuel in the engine that drives the play. These jealousies even lead to further false suspicions, including his belief that both Othello and Cassio have slept with his wife.

As one looks more deeply into the play and its characters, one sees a rich and compelling examination of the human psyche, heart and soul—one that rivals Shakespeare's other great tragedies.

Honest Deceptions?

Perceptions can be deceiving, especially when a spin-doctor is the source of all the villainous machinations. Iago is called "honest" fifteen times in the play. It's interesting to note that the word appears a total of 42 times in this play of deception.

Othello Who?

Despite being the titular character in the play, Othello's name is rarely stated. More often he is referred to as "the Moor", "general", "husband", and several rather offensive titles given him by Iago and Roderigo. Even those closest to him more often refer to him by his standing rather than his given name.

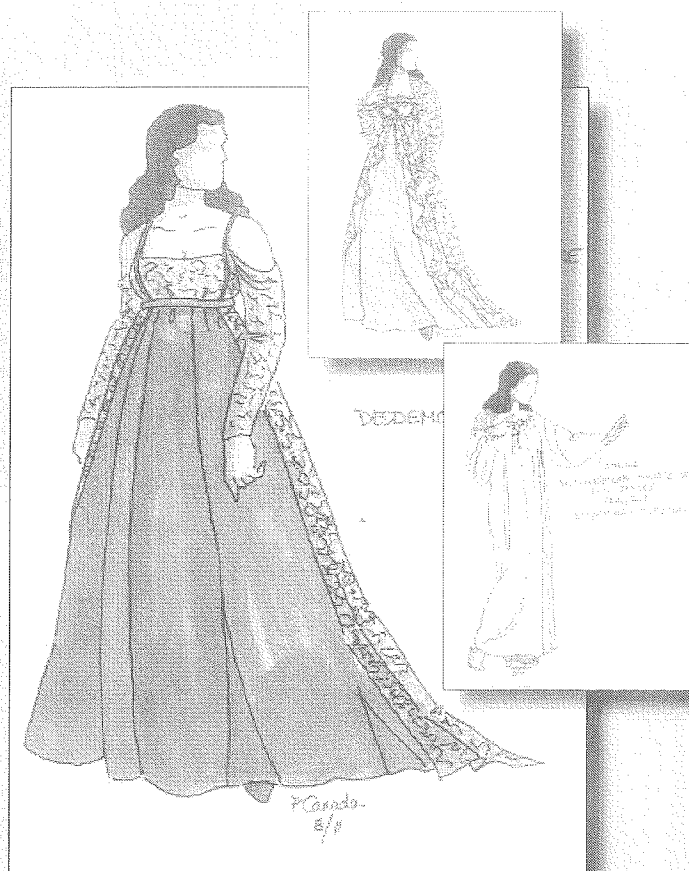
Though he is the sole subject of the events in the first three scenes of the play, his name is not stated until he arrives at court before the Duke, two and half scenes into the play.

On the Issue of Racism:

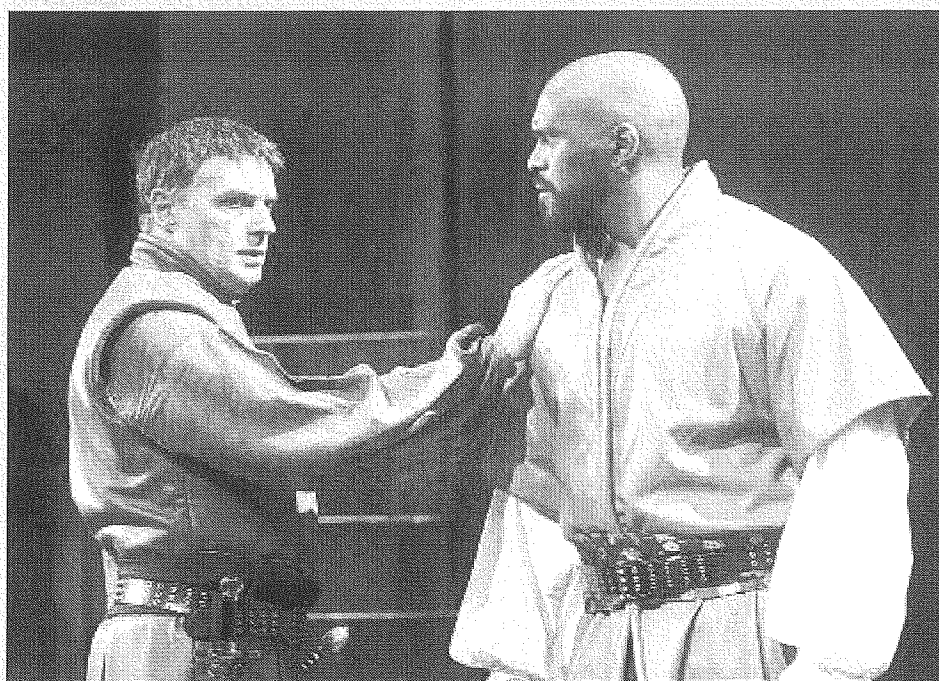
"I think this play is racist, and I think it is not. But *Othello's* example shows me that if I insist on resolving the contradiction, I will forge only lies and distortion. As this exploration of texts has shown, the discourse of racial difference is inescapably embedded in the play just as it was embedded in Shakespeare's culture and our own. To be totally free of racism, one would have to invent a new language with no loaded words, no color discriminations, and no associations of blackness with evil, whiteness with good. White and black are opposed in the play's language – in what we hear – and in what we see during performance. When Shakespeare tackled Cinthio's tale of a Moor and his ancient, he had no choice but to use this discourse. Shakespeare, and we, are necessarily implicated in its tangled web.

The wonder of *Othello* is that Shakespeare was able to exploit the full complexity of that discourse, showing expectations gone topsy-turvy with a white villain opposed to a black man of heroic proportion. Even though the predominant typology of white over black is only temporarily subverted in fits and starts within the play, that subversion is itself an incredible artistic triumph."

-Virginia Mason Vaughan



Costume renderings of Desdemona by Paul Canada.



Iago and Othello (Robert Cuccioli and Lindsay Smiling) in The Shakespeare Theatre production of *Othello*.
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